

Temple of the Inscriptions

A funerary monument for K'inich Janaab' Pakal, ruler of the Maya city-state of Palenque



Situated in the present-day Mexican state of Chiapas, Palenque was one of the most important of the Maya cities. It became established as a trading center during the Classic Period of the Maya civilization (c.250–900 CE), when it was known by its Maya name of Lakamha, and reached its heyday during the rule of K'inich Janaab' Pakal, or Pacal the Great, who reigned from 615 CE until his death in 683 CE.

Reclaimed from the forest

Only a fraction of the city has been recovered from the forest, but what has been discovered includes some of the finest examples of late Classic Maya architecture, such as Pakal's royal palace and the funerary pyramid built to house his tomb. At the top of the nine-tiered pyramid, which is approached by a staircase of 69 steps, is the Temple of the Inscriptions, so called because of the extensive hieroglyphic texts carved on the tablets on its inner walls and the sculpted panels on the piers separating the five entrances.

The Palenque dynasty collapsed in about 800 CE, and the city was overtaken by forest; it has only gradually been rediscovered since the late 18th century.

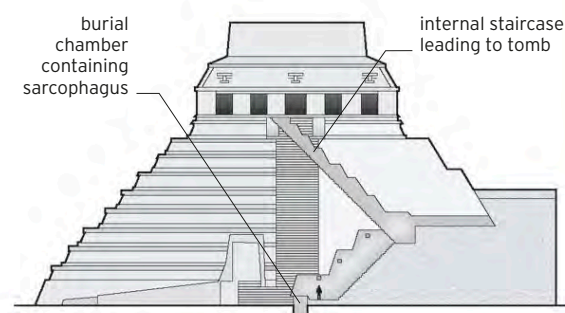


△ PAKAL'S BURIAL MASK

This jade death mask was found among the treasures in Pakal's burial chamber; its eyes are made from seashells and obsidian.

THE BURIAL CHAMBER

Within the temple, one of the slabs of the floor can be lifted to gain access to the inner staircase leading down to Pakal's tomb. The sarcophagus containing his remains and funerary goods is topped with a huge stone slab, carved with a depiction of the ruler entering the underworld.



This is the only known Maya **funerary pyramid** built during its occupant's life



▽ IMAGINING THE FACADE

Like the other structures in Palenque, the pyramid was originally adorned with paint and stucco decorations. Of the original roof comb—a typical feature of Maya structures—only stubs remain.